

Skills

Skills are not the tools, but how you use the tools. A character cannot raise a skill above the rank of its governing Stat. If there is no requirement you may choose the stat that governs the skill.

Designing Your Own Skills

Creating custom skills is a core feature of the Character Control System. Players are encouraged to build new skills that reflect unique playstyles, cultural identities, or magical ideas. However, custom skills must follow these mechanical rules and be submitted for GM review before they are used in play.

The following design notes reflect the natural balance assumptions of the system, and should inform both players and GMs when evaluating or creating custom skills:

- **Standard Ability Costs:** Most abilities cost **2 AP** (1 second of thought, 1 second of action). Larger or more powerful abilities cost **3 AP** (representing 2 relative seconds of sustained action).
- **SP/MP Cost Guidelines:** Typical SP/MP cost is **1× the Rank** for a 2 AP single target ability and **2x the Rank** for short Range directional AOE, and **2× the Rank** for a 3 AP high impact single target ability, **3x the Rank** for heavy AOE abilities, and **4x the Rank** if introducing range or other powerful effects.
- **Area of Effect (AoE) Evaluation:** When evaluating AoE balance, assume a functional AoE can hit **3 targets** unless the shape or targeting condition significantly limits that potential (e.g., a narrow 5-foot arc).
- **High Damage Rolls:** If an ability produces **above-average base damage**, it should **cost 3x or more MP/SP per Rank** by default. Because each rank allows for more d6 to be rolled a good rule of thumb is if the ability without other modifiers increases its damage by 4 or more per dice rolled on a single target. For AOE this would be multiplied by 3, thus 12.
- **Stacking Limits:** At early ranks, characters can typically only use **one ability** at a time, until combo skills are factored. This limits overstacking naturally. An ability uses AP to take an action. **Affinity** bonuses stack when an Affinity has a requirement for another affinity. If multiple Affinities exist on one Character, the Character can only apply a number of Affinity passive bonuses equal to their biggest Stat to any one ability being used.
- **Synergy Control:** Passive bonuses and complex combos are possible, but synergy with "high-power" skills is gated by intentional design limits. Character-created skills are expected to scale horizontally, not explosively.

These expectations provide a natural ceiling for early-game power while allowing advanced characters to express specialization through progression. Use the rubric below to formally review submitted skills.

Step 1: Choose a Governing Stat

All skills are governed by one of the three core stats—**Body (BDY)**, **Spirit (SPT)**, or **Mind (MND)**. The skill's **maximum rank** may not exceed the highest governing stat rank.

Step 2: Define the Skill Type

- **Proficiency** – Unlocks the potential of equipment and improves use of item type.
- **Combat Style** – Used in offense, defense, or initiative-based play
- **Perception** – Involves noticing things using sensory organs (sight, sound, etc)
- **Social** – Involves social encounters and interaction
- **Affinity** – Grants abilities that require Affinity attunement.
- **Crafting** – Used to create, enhance, or manipulate equipment

Step 3: Assign Rank-Based Abilities

Each Rank (1–5) should provide a **distinct ability**. These abilities should scale in complexity and impact as the Rank increases. Most skills provide **active abilities** that cost a combination of **AP**, **SP**, and/or **MP** to use.

Skill Ranks never grant additional dice. Dice rolled for any action are based solely on Stat Rank.

Step 4: Assign Costs and Effects

- **Every activated ability must cost AP** to use, but can be reduced with additional Skills or Ranks.
- **Most abilities also cost SP or MP** based on their natural scaling with Rank.
- Abilities should scale with Rank and have clear effects and conditions, and may include synergy with status effects, movement, equipment, or other skills

Step 5: Submit for GM Review

All custom skills must be reviewed and approved by the GM. The GM has the authority to request changes for balance or clarity. Players are encouraged to work with the GM to refine their skills into options that are both fun and fair for the group.

Designing your own skills should be treated as an opportunity to enrich your character concept—not to bypass balance or dominate combat.

Skill Template

Skill Name:

Governing Stat:

Req:

Rank 1: Usually a Static Rank scaling bonus

Rank 2: Usually a Resources regeneration mechanic, but sometimes an ability

Rank 3: Power attack or special defense. This is where the bell curve starts going up.

Rank 4: Specialized buffs or ability

Rank 5: Specialized buffs or ability.

All the skills presented here are provided as Examples, with flavor. Many are designed for use in Ciretose (book to be released at a later date), but again, the system is designed for stylized freedom. These examples are not all encompassing. They are just examples for how skills are intended to be built. Always consider the action economy and minimize additions to AP to preserve combat flow, instead lean into **SP**, **MP**, and even **HP** costs vs the value of the output. How much damage or healing it does, with how many targets it hits in mind. The average of a d6 is 3.5, which is what all Rank1 attacks will roll, so bonuses should not exceed 4 at this Rank. Typically Rank 1 gives a +1 bonus, but a high costing ability may have a higher value.